

[Skip to main content](#)

r/DebateReligion



Search in r/D...



Create



r/DebateReligion • 4y ago

HiddenAgnosticYt

Agnostic



The Birth of Jesus was Written with Proven Historical Errors

Christianity

There are many things in the Bible related to the birth of Jesus which have been proven wrong. This means that these gospels could not be divinely inspired. Error #1: Mary and Joseph what not have gone to Bethlehem. The Bible states that Mary and Joseph had to travel to Bethlehem because there was a census. However, that is not how census's worked. One wouldn't have to travel back to their hometown. They would be counted in their current town. The Roman empire did not make people go back to their hometown. Mary and Joseph would have had to stay where they current were. Them going back to Bethlehem could not have happened.

Error #2: Herod was not in charge during the census. He had died 9 years before it. This means that both Luke and Matthew have an error.

If the Bible was divinely inspired, God would have known these weren't true



Archived post. New comments cannot be posted and votes cannot be cast.

61

135



Share

monday_com • Promoted



The numbers don't lie - there's a reason why 10,000+ customers rate monday.com 5 stars and use it as their work management platform. It's the #1 platform to efficiently manage your team, work, and processes. Try it now!

[Sign Up](#)

monday.com

Sort by: **New (Default)** ▾

Search Comments

**AutoModerator MOD** • 4y ago • Stickied comment

100PercentGarlic • 4y ago

catholic

That would suggest people of the time would have known there was no census. Then why put it in? Matthew and Luke were written sometime in the first century when people would easily have been able to

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

based on proof by absence. We are projecting back our desire for proof. We want extra-Biblical evidence two millennia after the fact when it seems like contemporaries of Jesus were unconcerned with this detail.

⊖ ↑ 0 ↓ ...



HiddenAgnosticYt OP • 4y ago

Agnostic

There was a census. Just not when they said there was.

So the writers knew there was a census. They just got the details wrong

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



100PercentGarlic • 4y ago

catholic

I'll summarize my points.

It's not a "proven historical error" if we just mean there's no *other* sources to back up this claim. That's proof by absence. Christians were hated enough that I would expect their enemies would have wanted to point out how silly it was that one of their gospels has such an obvious mistake in it. Especially since their enemies included Romans and Jews who would have been aware if the census was a fabrication. Without that evidence, it is factually incorrect to say the census is a "proven historical error."

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



HiddenAgnosticYt OP • 4y ago

Agnostic

No, it is a proven error.

It is proven that there was a census when Herod was not king.

Bible says there was a census when Herod was king.

That is a proven historical error. That is not evidence of absence or anything like that.

Also, gospels were written between 50-100 years after the events took place. It's obvious the writers knew there was a census and knew that Herod was king around that time but didn't have a way to know Herod had died 9 years before the census.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



100PercentGarlic • 4y ago

catholic

You are saying there was a census that occurred 9 years after Herod's death. How does that prove there wasn't a census while Herod was alive? That is still proof by absence.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



HiddenAgnosticYt OP • 4y ago

Agnostic

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

How? In the same way you *know* there aren't any black swans?

↑ 1 ↓ ...

**Korach** • 4y ago

Atheist

If the last 5 years didn't happen, I might have agreed with a point like this.

It's clear, though, that people are capable of believing things to be true - with all their being - with zero evidence.

The Q movement is the best example of how fiction can be believed as truth by a large portion of people.

If belief in Jesus as a special being was important enough to his followers, it's not strange to think they'll ignore or create evidence (or allege evidence) that points to that "truth"

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...

**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

But there was massive push-back against the Q movement. That's the *point*. If something was seen as untrue *and* it came from a despised religion, that would have left a mark.

⊖ ↑ 0 ↓ ...

**Korach** • 4y ago

Atheist

You're saying it like everyone who heard about Jesus converted.

The point is that just because people believed it to be true, doesn't make it true.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

I'm literally saying the opposite. There was great opposition to Jesus' ministry (he *was* crucified after all). My point is that in the face of this opposition, early opponents to Christianity didn't talk about the "census controversy" in a way that left records, likely because it wasn't a controversy two thousand years ago.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**Korach** • 4y ago

Atheist

Or they're like Qanon people who believe insane things for bad reasons.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

I'm trying to give reasons that Romans and Jews would have tried to discredit Christians. If all you have left to defend your position is some speculative fiction about a super conspiracy bigger than Qanon, big enough that *even the people who hated Christians* fell into it, then I don't think you are being properly skeptical anymore.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**Korach** • 4y ago

Atheist

I thought I responded to this - looks like not.

So your point is because we don't have a record of people pushing back against a specific inaccuracy in the bible (ex: the details of the census), we should assume it was true?

I suppose that means that you assume the gospels were widely read outside of the believer group - at least by critics.

Do we know how widely read it was? Do we have ancient textual analysis from people that would push back? (Like the Jews of the time...).

(I have no idea - serious questions)

I know there's some mention in the Talmud - but that's we over 100 years from the time.

↑ 1 ↓ ...

**Geass10** • 4y ago

Mistakes happen, fit a narrative, and they obviously don't want the religion to fall apart. I mean we know these events and many more never happened. So what do we do with them?

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

We know they never happened? No, that is more proof by absence. These people would know know whether or not their parents or grandparents had to take a census.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...

**HiddenAgnosticYt** OP • 4y ago

Agnostic

The census did happen. Just not when Herod was King

↑ 1 ↓ ...

**Geass10** • 4y ago

We have no reason to believe it happened.

How do you know?

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create catholic

We *do* have reason the believe it happened. I know I'll get laughed at for using the Bible as a source, but any good historian would accept the Bible as documents bound to a specific time and place. It's not all fairy tales, the gospels talk about an actual moment in time. The fact that there is no dissenting opinions on the census besides thousands of years after the fact lends credence to the census occuring. If the census didn't happen, the Jews and Romans would have had reason to discredit Christians by it.

 1  ...
**[deleted]** • 4y ago

There was no Internet back then. A lot of people couldn't read or write. Most people would have no way of knowing wether a census occurred in a place hundreds/thousands of miles from where they lived, decades prior. If people in the Roman Empire were told that Herod had performed a census, and demanded people return to their birthplace, I don't see how they'd be able to easily check if that was true.

I doubt if many people would have gone to the effort of sorting truth from fabrication in any case. Even now that the Internet exists, only a minority of people will ever use it to investigate the gospels. I honestly think I've never met anyone in real life who has.

  1  ...
**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

People would have been massively interested in knowing the truth about a man claiming to be God. Maybe people in Spain or China didn't care, but Israel cared. Early Christians cared.

No, there was no internet, but people travelled and asked questions. Herodotus' *Histories* is similar to Luke's gospel because they asked people connected to these events to share details. It was a cruder method than what we have now, but it was still allowed the accurate collection and dissemination of facts.

  1  ...
**[deleted]** • 4y ago

People may have been interested, but that doesn't give them the ability to satisfy their interest. Most of them would have been unable to travel, or even read. Whether they cared us neither here nor there. Their choices were to believe or disbelieve.

There is no evidence that the anonymous author of Luke actually asked any primary sources for his gospel. The same for all of the gospels. They are four stories written without input from eyewitnesses, and no method of fact checking. They don't even agree on some things, so their accuracy is dubious to say the least.

  1  ...
**100PercentGarlic** • 4y ago

catholic

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

... didn't simply blindly accept whatever nonsense was put in front of them. People rejected Jesus' divinity, but no one seemed to reject the census.

Let's put this into perspective. Some people used to believe Pontius Pilate was a fictional character because he couldn't be verified in extra-Biblical sources. That is, until sources *were* found. They were scattered, but they confirmed his existence.

Simply said, if you're familiar with ancient and classical history and aren't ready to throw out the entire field of history, then understanding the historicity of the Bible isn't hard.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

I never said people didn't travel. The average lower class citizen simply wouldn't be able to afford to leave their job for months to travel by foot across the empire to check for evidence of the census in the local government buildings, especially decades after the fact.

I wouldn't believe in Pilate either without evidence. Most of the NT is still badly in need of that kind of supporting evidence.

Understanding the historicity of the Bible doesn't solve the issue of lacking citations. The existence of a man called Yeshua who was a Jewish preacher can be accepted. The miracles and resurrection on the other hand are badly in need of evidence, which is suspiciously absent. The NT isn't as fictionalised as the OT, but that isn't saying much, and it still reads as a set of fantastical stories.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



100PercentGarlic • 4y ago

catholic

You are jumping the gun. We were talking about a *census* and now you want to talk about miracles. Friend, the Bible is a historical document bound to a time and place. You already agreed that the Bible remembered Pilate after the world forgot about him. That's probably what happened with this census, especially since there's not ancient documents accusing Christians of inventing a census. As a person with a degree in history, who was an atheist while I earned that degree, I don't think you just can expect ancient writers to cater to your post-enlightenment scruples on evidence. If you are this distrusting of the Bible, then you shouldn't even believe Julius Caesar existed.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

My point was that the Bible isn't historical, even if there are historical figures in it. Jesus was already historical, like Pilate. His inclusion doesn't make the gospels any less unreliable.

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

Pilate is real or not.

Julius Caesar is a completely different scenario. There are multiple nonfictional sources that he existed.

The bible literally can't be particularly historical, since it tells multiple versions of the same story.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



100PercentGarlic • 4y ago

catholic

Do you hear yourself? You have pre-determined that the Bible is a fictional source. You have gone outside any historical methodology to justify your own belief that the Bible isn't worth listening to. **You are not a skeptic, you are a simple naysayer.** How do I know this? Because you just *declare* that the gospels are different from *The Conquest of Gaul* without even explaining why. Did you know the Romans declared Julius Caesar a god? Does that make Julius' books and existence any less historical? Post this on [r/badhistory](#) and see if people make fun of me for believing the gospels are historical documents.

All this because it's too big of a stretch for you to consider that the Bible recorded a census that has been otherwise lost to history? Despite acknowledging that similar doubts existed about Pontius Pilate before?

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

I didn't predetermine anything. I looked for primary sources for the events in the gospels, and found none. Suspicious, considering the alleged numbers of witnesses. I compared the narratives of the gospels, and found them to contain literary techniques such as dramatic irony, often found in works of fiction. Again, suspicious. It is also notable that the gospels aren't even in agreement on certain things, which further enforces the idea that none of them can truly be trusted as sources of information in and of themselves.

If you have any evidence for this census, feel free to share it. I'll weigh it fairly. Until then, we can't compare the census to Pilate, because we only have evidence for one of them.

I didn't mention the conquest of Gaul. Whether the Romans declared Julius Caesar God is neither here nor there. We know that he existed, and we have primary sources for the events of his life. My beliefs concerning Caesar are based on historians' interpretation of these. Here's the first link that comes up:

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

that real people and places are mentioned. The same could be said of the novel and film Abraham Lincoln: Vampire Hunter. It's a lot like John in particular: farfetched, fantastical, and written a long time after the historical figure died.

↑ 1 ↓ ...

[+ More replies](#)



Stagnu_Demorte • 4y ago

The first could just be Joseph committing census fraud to increase his family's homes political power. Did they allocate governor's or something based on that?

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



HiddenAgnosticYt [OP](#) • 4y ago

Agnostic

I'm honestly not sure the answer to that question.

Although, does it really seem likely that Joseph made his extremely pregnant wife partake on a pretty difficult travel for more influence?

↑ 1 ↓ ...



canoe6998 • 4y ago

Great debate here. I was happy to see so much agreement that the idea of a census dictating that people Return to the town of those birth or their ancestors birth was beyond unlikely.

We have enough evidence of scribes over the years changing biblical text to put this in that category also.

Plus the logistics alone would have been next to impossible. All people returning to a different town would crush economies of towns and leave homes open to pillaging.

It's a silly suggestion that stands out quickly in this book.

⊖ ↑ 3 ↓ ...



How_Are_You_True_ • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

I'll share the edict of Vibus here if I may. I haven't yet recieved a response as to whether or not this is definate proof. But it appears to me to be proof that these people did in fact return to their homes/properties every 14 years.

https://droitromain.univ-grenoble-alpes.fr/Anglica/Aegypti29_johnson.htm

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

1 ...

**August3** • 4y ago

I find it odd that the arrival of God on earth is only covered by Matthew and Luke, and they weren't there.

2 ...

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Those fictions were written anonymously, not by the ones whose names were assigned to them by the early church. None of the "gospels" were signed, and it is unknown who actually wrote them.

2 ...

**How_Are_You_True_** • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

This is addressing your second supposed error. (Also your first, actually)

At the Time of Jesus' Birth two registrations are mentioned in the Christian Greek Scriptures as taking place after Judea came under subjection to Rome.

Such were not merely to ascertain population figures but, rather, were mainly for purposes of taxation and conscription of men for military service.

Concerning the first of these we read: "Now in those days [c. 2 B.C.E.] a decree went forth from Caesar Augustus for all the inhabited earth to be registered; (this first registration took place when Quirinius was governor of Syria;) and all people went traveling to be registered, each one to his own city." (Luke 2:1-3)

This edict of the emperor proved providential, for it compelled Joseph and Mary to journey from the city of Nazareth to Bethlehem in spite of the fact that Mary was then heavy with child; thus Jesus was born in the city of David in fulfillment of prophecy.

Two registrations under Quirinius. Bible critics have said that the only census taken while Publius Sulpicius Quirinius was governor of Syria was about 6 C.E., which event sparked a rebellion by Judas the Galilean and the Zealots. (Acts 5:37) This was really the second registration under Quirinius, for inscriptions discovered at and near Antioch revealed that some years earlier Quirinius had served as the emperor's legate in Syria. (The Bearing of Recent Discovery on the Trustworthiness of the New Testament, by W. Ramsay, 1979, pp. 285, 291)

Concerning this, the Dictionnaire du Nouveau Testament in Crampon's French Bible (1939 ed., p. 360) says: "The scholarly researches of Zumpt (Commentat. epigraph., II, 86-104; De Syria romana provincia, 97-98) and of Mommsen (Res gestae divi Augusti) place beyond doubt that Quirinius was twice governor of Syria."

Many scholars locate the time of Quirinius' first governorship as somewhere between the years 4 and 1 B.C.E., probably from 3 to 2 B.C.E. Their method of arriving at these dates, however, is not solid, and the

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

So historian and Bible writer Luke was correct when he said concerning the registration at the time of Jesus' birth: "This first registration took place when Quirinius was governor of Syria," distinguishing it from the second, which occurred later under the same Quirinius and to which Gamaliel makes reference as reported by Luke at Acts 5:37.

⊖ ↑ 5 ↓ ...

⊕ **[deleted]** • 4y ago



Brokenhill • 4y ago

Keep up the good work.

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...



How_Are_You_True_ • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

I won't take credit for this research.

That reply is an excerpt I found in a book produced by Jehovah's Witnesses:

<https://wol.jw.org/en/wol/d/r1/lp-e/1200003676?q=Quirinius&p=par>

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Find an independently produced secular scholarly work that confirms those claims. JWs have cause to produce biased materials, and much of what they produce is provably propaganda.

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...



How_Are_You_True_ • 4y ago

Was this an actual rebuttal?

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Yes, a single source with history of bias is not a valid source.

↑ 2 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

plus there was no census the year Jesus was born. but herod antipas took over after his dad

↑ 9 ↓ ...

⊕ **[deleted]** • 4y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

that's where they travelled to

⊖ ↑ -3 ↓ ...



Protowhale • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

There is absolutely no record of a census which required people to travel to the home town of an ancestor from several centuries ago. If you had to go to the home town of a distant ancestor for a census, where would you go? How would you know which of hundreds of ancestors to pick? Any Roman census was for the purpose of taxation, so people were counted where they lived. The whole story is ridiculous. The Romans were able administrators who managed a tax system that spanned a huge area. What possible use would it be for them to count the descendants who randomly picked an ancestor from that particular town? Face it, telling everyone to pick a long-ago ancestor and go to their town is an utterly ridiculous way to conduct a census.

⊖ ↑ 14 ↓ ...



napoleonsolo • 4y ago
atheist

Even if it was your father, why? Just, why? It makes no sense.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



DrVol_97 • 4y ago

Exactly. What if they immigrated to the Roman empire? What would happen then

↑ 1 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

[Census of Quirinius](#) Happened in 6 CE. So clearly it was forged many years after his alleged Birth.

This was done in order to fulfill the prophecy of coming of messiah. Jews were technically correct. Jesus didn't fulfill the prophecy. So he wasn't the Christ

↑ 10 ↓ ...



rumoursofwar • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

The only dates known in the life of Quirinius are the dates of his consulship in 12 BC, his second government of Syria beginning in 6 AD, his prosecution of Domitia Lepida in 20 AD and his death in 21 AD. It is also agreed that sometime between 12 BC and 6 AD, he led the war against the Homonadenses. So, much of what is known about Quirinius's life around the time of Christ's birth is unknown.

Luke does not necessarily say that Quirinius was holding the office of Governor of Syria during that census. In the original Greek, it says he was *governing* or, *acting as a leader* in Syria (see Strong's concordance G2230 versus G2232). Finally, it seems from Luke 2:2 that this was the first of at least two censuses conducted during that time.

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

Agnostic

Oh great, another nobody who knows ancient Greek better than the scholars who have devoted their lives to its study. Please list your credentials that entitle you to say that all the translations are wrong.

<https://www.biblehub.com/luke/2-2.htm>

Syria was a Roman Province. It didn't have random people "acting as a leader," it had a GOVERNOR.

That aside, we know a lot about Roman administration of that time, and everyone, even devout Christian scholars, agrees that there was never, ever, a census of the entire Roman empire that required people to travel to whatever city their ancestors lived in 1000 years earlier. It would be impossible on at least three counts:

1. Nobody would be that stupid
2. Hardly anybody would know where to go. Most people today, even with the internet, have no idea where their ancestors lived 1000 years ago.
3. It would be logistically impossible. There were Roman citizens (and Mary and Joseph were NOT Roman citizens, so the census wouldn't apply to them anyway) living in northern Europe whose ancestors were from Africa or Arabia. It would take them a year to travel to their ancestral home and back. If the whole empire was doing it, business and commerce would be paralyzed, and income would plummet. Not the best way to raise taxes.

⊖ ↑ 13 ↓ ...



rumoursofwar • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

Oh great, another nobody who knows ancient Greek better than the scholars who have devoted their lives to its study. Please list your credentials that entitle you to say that all the translations are wrong.

Absolutely. I'm not an expert here. That's why I deferred to Strong's concordance. ἡγεμονεύω.
<https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/g2230/kjv/tr/0-1/>

Syria was a Roman Province. It didn't have random people "acting as a leader," it had a GOVERNOR.

In order for Quirinius to fit the role described by Luke, he simply needed to be "acting as a leader" in some capacity at the time that the first census was being carried out.

That aside, we know a lot about Roman administration of that time, and everyone, even devout Christian scholars, agrees that there was never, ever, a census of the entire Roman empire that required people to travel to whatever city their ancestors lived in 1000 years earlier. It would be impossible on at least three counts:

1. Nobody would be that stupid
2. Hardly anybody would know where to go. Most people today, even with the internet, have no idea where their ancestors lived 1000

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

them a year to travel to their ancestral home and back. If the whole empire was doing it, business and commerce would be paralyzed, and income would plummet. Not the best way to raise taxes.

What's your point? History believes that there was a census because there is enough historical evidence to say this. I'm not sure that anyone is claiming that the census or registration process required one to travel to the city of their ancient ancestors. I'm not understanding what you are trying to prove here.

⊖ ↑ -2 ↓ ...



[deleted] • 4y ago

I'm not sure that anyone is claiming that the census or registration process required one to travel to the city of their ancient ancestors

The bible story says

And everyone went to their own town to register. So Joseph also went up from the town of Nazareth in Galilee to Judea, to Bethlehem the town of David, because he belonged to the house and line of David.

And yes, it's pretty absurd that a population census would require people to travel to the birthplace of whoever their most famous ancestor was. That's just idiotic. It would throw the entire empire into turmoil, which makes it double suspicious that Matthew doesn't even mention it, just like Luke's massive baby genocide that Matthew doesn't feel is worth mentioning. Clearly both the baby genocide, and the census migration, are just two different authors making up lame fanfic explanations to justify why Jesus can both be a nazarene and yet also be born in bethlehem.

⊖ ↑ 8 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

A major issue with thinking of the Gospels as historically accurate is that in terms of time Matthew and Luke do not agree as to when Jesus was born. Matthew specifically puts it 6 to 4 BCE while Luke, with his reference to Quirinius establishes it as being no earlier than 6 CE.

Apologists try to handwave this conflict away with various claims that are not supported by history. Here is the historical reality of the period 6 BC to 6 CE:

Publius Sulpicius Quirinius was fighting some two provinces to the east a minimum of 6-3 BCE with him being Duumvir of the area 6-1 BCE.[34] and some say the war goes back as far as to 12 BCE.

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



In Antiquities 17:27 Josephus expressly stated "the Judaeen kingdom was immune from Roman taxation for as long as Herod lived ... this immunity seems to have remained in force even after Herod's death during the rule of his son Archelaus (4BC - AD6)" Therefore, Luke's taxation census must have occurred after Herod's death, while Matthew requires it to have happened before.

While Herod Archelaus' removal as Ethnarch of Judea (where Bethlehem of Judea is) made it subject to Roman taxation, Herod Antipas remained Tetrarch of Galilee (where Nazareth is) clear until 41 CE, making its subjects exempt from the Judean census, so the reason given by Luke for the trip makes no sense.

Because ΙΟΥΔΑΙΑΣ could refer to all Palestine or the southern portion of Palestine lying on this side of the Jordan and the Dead Sea, to distinguish it from Samaria, Galilee, Peraea, and Idumaea Luke 1:5's ΗΡΩΔΟΥ ΒΑΣΙΛΕΩΣ ΤΗΣ ΙΟΥΔΑΙΑΣ could refer to either Herod the Great or Herod Archelaus with Luke 2:2 indicating the later Herod.

A little-known fact is that in the time period Jesus supposedly lived there was a Bethlehem of Zebulun (around 10 kilometres north-west of Nazareth and 30 kilometres east of Haifa, i.e. in Galilee) and it has been suggested that this is the Bethlehem Jesus really came from.

Moreover, a census would not and has never meant ordering a return to the town people were born in, but rather taking records of them where they live at the time. The alternative would be a logistical nightmare in which the roads would be clogged with travelers returning to their home towns throughout all of Judea, making a census-taking far more difficult. This part of the story likely was added so that Joseph (who is said to come from the House of David—i.e. the royal line) would return to Bethlehem so Jesus could be born there, thus fulfilling a supposed old prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah. However, some translations of Micah 5:2 make it clear that the supposed "Bethlehem" prophecy is in reference to a group of people in Judea, not a town, so there is no prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah being born in the town of Bethlehem but rather coming from the Bethlehem clan who could have been anywhere in the land that had once been called Judea.

Finally Matthew implies that nearly two years had passed since Jesus' family had fled to Egypt when Herod starting killing the children in and around Bethlehem while Luke expressly states they went to temple every year.

↑ 1 ↓ ...



Drivngspaghtemonster • 4y ago

How are you reading that as saying people were required to travel to where their famous ancestor was from?

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

2 ...

**Drivngspaghtemonster** • 4y ago

Because it doesn't say that. I read it as that was where Joseph was from.

1 ...

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Then you are interpreting it to fit your preconception.

1 ...

**Drivngspaghtemonster** • 4y ago

Or that's just what it says. To each their own though. Be well.

1 ...

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

And everyone went to their own town to register.

So Joseph also went up from the town of Nazareth in Galilee to Judea, to Bethlehem the town of David, because he belonged to the house and line of David.

It says nothing about it being where he was from, only that it was where his "house and line" were from. "House and Line" refers to his ancestors and bloodline family, not where he was from, just his family line and ancestors.

2 ...

More replies

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

So Joseph also went up from the town of Nazareth in Galilee to Judea, to Bethlehem the town of David, **because he belonged to the house and line of David.**

I bolded the part that explicitly and literally says exactly that.

2 ...

**Drivngspaghtemonster** • 4y ago

Right....that doesn't state it's the requirement. It could be explaining why his family was from there.

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

1 ...

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

It could be explaining why his family was from there.

That doesn't explain why his family is from there. Families move all the time, without affecting which house and line the descendants belong to. For instance, in this very story.

You sound like those people who go up to asian americans and say "where are you from?", and if they say they were born in Pittsburgh, and so were their parents, you follow up "yeah, but like, where are you *from*? wink wink."

1 ...

**Drivngspaghtemonster** • 4y ago

You mean like Trump? No thanks.

You're missing it. I'm saying it seems like Joseph himself was from there. His relation to David specifically is irrelevant to the census.

1 ...

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

His relation to David specifically is irrelevant to the census.

And yet it's explicitly given as the justification for why he went to Bethlehem.

/shrug

I guess I can't prove it wasn't written with a bunch of meaningless words that don't mean what they clearly sound like. We've certainly hashed out all the available evidence. I think it's pretty clear, and yet you disagree. Oh well. I'm out.

1 ...

[+ More replies](#)**rumoursofwar** • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

I don't read Matthew 2:1-7 as saying that the requirement of the Roman government was necessarily that all people return to the city of their ancestors. I do read that the requirement by Caesar was that all be registered, and that Joseph returned to Bethlehem for this purpose.

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

anti-theist / humanist

Yet, such a journey would be completely unnecessary and pose massive logistical issues for millions of people. No such thing ever happened.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



rumoursofwar • 4y ago

Do you have legitimate evidence for this belief that no census took place?

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

A census clearly took place, several in fact, both happening *after* the supposed birth of "Jesus".

In Antiquities 17:27 Josephus expressly stated "the Judaeian kingdom was immune from Roman taxation for as long as Herod lived ... this immunity seems to have remained in force even after Herod's death during the rule of his son Archelaus (4BC - AD6)". **Therefore, Luke's taxation census must have occurred after Herod's death, while Matthew requires it to have happened before.**

While Herod Archelaus' removal as Ethnarch of Judea (where Bethlehem of Judea is) made it subject to Roman taxation, Herod Antipas remained Tetrarch of Galilee (where Nazareth is) clear until 41 CE, making its subjects exempt from the Judean census, so the reason given by Luke for the trip makes no sense.

Moreover, a census would not and has never meant ordering a return to the town people were born in, but rather taking records of them where they live at the time. The alternative would be a logistical nightmare in which the roads would be clogged with travelers returning to their home towns throughout all of Judea, making a census-taking far more difficult.

This part of the story was likely added solely so that Joseph (who was said to come from the House of David—i.e. the royal line) would return to Bethlehem so Jesus could be born there, thus fulfilling a supposed old prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah.

However, some translations of Micah 5:2 make it clear that the supposed "Bethlehem" prophecy is in reference to a group of people in Judea, not a town, so there is no prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah being born in the town of Bethlehem but rather coming from the Bethlehem clan who could have been anywhere in the land that had once been called Judea.

⊖ ↑ 2 ↓ ...

rumoursofwar • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

[Skip to main content](#)

Create



In Antiquities 17:27 Josephus expressly stated "the Judean kingdom was immune from Roman taxation for as long as Herod lived ... this immunity seems to have remained in force even after Herod's death during the rule of his son Archelaus (4BC - AD6)". Therefore, Luke's taxation census must have occurred after Herod's death, while Matthew requires it to have happened before.

What taxation census? Luke doesn't talk about taxation.

While Herod Archelaus' removal as Ethnarch of Judea (where Bethlehem of Judea is) made it subject to Roman taxation, Herod Antipas remained Tetrarch of Galilee (where Nazareth is) clear until 41 CE, making its subjects exempt from the Judean census, so the reason given by Luke for the trip makes no sense.

Once again, taxation vs census.

Moreover, a census would not and has never meant ordering a return to the town people were born in, but rather taking records of them where they live at the time. The alternative would be a logistical nightmare in which the roads would be clogged with travelers returning to their home towns throughout all of Judea, making a census-taking far more difficult.

This part of the story was likely added solely so that Joseph (who was said to come from the House of David—i.e. the royal line) would return to Bethlehem so Jesus could be born there, thus fulfilling a supposed old prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah.

Egyptian papyrus of 104 AD has Roman orders to return home for census. So its not a completely ridiculous idea.

But, Luke doesn't even necessarily say that all were required to return to the home of their ancestors for that census. Luke just says that Joseph and Mary returned home for the census, which isn't necessarily the same thing. But yes, this was to fulfill prophecy.

However, some translations of Micah 5:2 make it clear that the supposed "Bethlehem" prophecy is in reference to a group of people in Judea, not a town, so there is no prophecy regarding the Jewish Messiah being born in the town of Bethlehem but rather coming from the Bethlehem clan who could have been anywhere in the land that had once been called Judea.

Different discussion. I'll take a closer look at this.

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

anti-theist / humanist

What taxation census? Luke doesn't talk about taxation.

That's why a census is taken, for the computation of taxation (primarily).

Once again, taxation vs census.

And once again you ignore the purpose of a census, and why Caesar would order one.

Egyptian papyrus of 104 AD has Roman orders to return home for census. So its not a completely ridiculous idea.

No, it has orders to return to their [nomes](#) which was a territorial division in ancient Egypt. The term nome comes from Ancient Greek νομός, nomós, meaning "district"; the Ancient Egyptian term was sepat or spAt. Today's use of the Ancient Greek rather than the Ancient Egyptian term came about during the Ptolemaic period, when the use of Greek was widespread in Egypt. The availability of Greek records on Egypt influenced the adoption of Greek terms by later historians.

The Papyrus actually reads from [Attalus - Select Papyri](#):

Proclamation of Gaius Vibius Maximus, praefect of Egypt. The house-to-house census having started, it is essential that all persons who for any reason whatsoever are absent from their nomes be summoned to return to their own hearths, in order that they may perform the customary business of registration and apply themselves to the cultivation which concerns them. Knowing, however, that some of the people from the country are needed by our city, I desire all those who think they have a satisfactory reason for remaining here to register themselves before . . . Festus, praefectus alae, whom I have appointed for this purpose, from whom those who have shown their presence to be necessary shall receive signed permits in accordance with this edict up to the 30th of the present month Epeiph.

This was written to order the people of Roman held Egypt to return to their farms and homesteads *within Egypt* in order to be enumerated for both taxation and conscription purposes. Notice, it makes an allowance for those who, for one reason or another, should remain in the city and how they could register themselves with the praefect Festus. This papyrus, written a century after the event in question, has little to no

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

Now, in Flavius' Josephus' account of the census in **6 C.E.** (just a bit late for "jesus" don't you think), he explicitly states that those people taxed were assessed of their possessions, including lands and livestock. *In other words, the census takers were also the tax assessors.* In Egypt these tax assessors went from house to house in order to perform their duties. With this in mind, let us look at a crucial error in Luke's account. Luke has Joseph and Mary making a three-day journey away from their home in Nazareth to register in their alleged ancestral home Bethlehem. But in the Egyptian papyrus recording a census in 104 C.E. it explicitly states that *"since registration by household is imminent, it is necessary to notify all who for any reason are absent from their districts to return to their own homes that they may carry out the ordinary business of registration...."* Unlike Matthew, who does not mention a census nor Nazareth as Mary and Joseph's home, Luke describes Nazareth as "their own city" (Lk. 2:39). If the rules of this Egyptian census applied to Palestine, **then Joseph and Mary should have stayed in Nazareth to be enrolled.**

In his famous book entitled *Jesus*, Charles Guignebert states:

"It is all outside the plane of reality....It is incredible that such an unusual and disturbing proceeding, as the census spoken of by Luke must necessarily have been, should have escaped all notice in Josephus...."

Guignebert continues, saying:

"We will not unduly stress the peculiarity of the mode of census taking implied in our text, but it is to be noted that it is a very strange proceeding. The moving about of men and families which this reckless decree must have caused throughout the whole of the Empire is almost beyond imagination, and one cannot help wondering what advantage there could be for the Roman state in this return, for a single day, of so many scattered individuals, not to the places of their birth, but to the original homes of their ancestors. For it is to be remembered that those of royal descent were not the only ones affected by this fantastic ordinance, and many a poor man must have been hard put to it to discover the cradle of his race. The suspicion, or rather, the conviction, is borne in upon us at first sight that the editor of Luke has simply been looking for some means of bringing Joseph and Mary to Bethlehem, in order to have Jesus born there. A hagiographer of his type never bothers much about common sense in inventing the circumstances he requires"

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)[↑ 1 ↓ ...](#)[+ More replies](#)**noclue2k** • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

Agnostic

just like Luke's massive baby genocide that Matthew doesn't feel is worth mentioning.

Other way around. Matthew has the massacre and the magic star, and later the zombie invasion of Jerusalem, which nobody else, secular or gospel, thought worthy of comment. Luke has the ridiculous census, plus Mary and Joseph presenting six-week-old Jesus in the Temple in Jerusalem with various holy people publicly proclaiming him the Messiah, half a mile from Herod's palace, and then calmly going home to Nazareth, completely unhindered by Herod or anyone else, and returning to Jerusalem every year for Passover. At the same time Matthew says they were cowering in Egypt, warned by God not to go near Jerusalem during the life of Herod, or even his successor, who reigned for another six years after Herod died.



4



...

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Also, there is no record of the massacre in any other Gospel or any extra-biblical historical source produced by the half dozen or so historians in that area at that time of anything like the slaughter described.

Not even by Josephus, who really didn't like Herod and was well known to have meticulously catalogued his other misdeeds.

The two stories in Matthew and Luke completely contradict each other in many, many other ways as well.



1



...

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

Additionally, something from the true god would've made sure there was no contradictions in his very own inspired word... contradictions such as law changes. Once god makes his mind up, he can't change it. God (according to the Bible doesn't change his mind like humans and doesn't lie). But just in the Torah alone he changed his mind on laws like someone changing their diaper every couple hours.



5



...

**CrunchyOldCrone** • 4y ago

Perennialist | Animist | Mystic

God changes his mind a few times to be fair. Abraham almost convinces him not to destroy Sodom and Gommorah in Genesis by slowly wittling down the number of righteous people God would want

[Skip to main content](#) Create**[deleted]** • 4y ago

Then the Bible contradicts it very self, god doesn't change his mind according to the Bible. And he can't lie. Once his mind is made up , he can't reverse it or change it again. That's what goes against the concept of yhwh nature.



1

**quicksilverg** • 4y ago

Where does it say this in the Bible? I feel like you're just making up facts.



2

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

Are you referring to me or the other guy?



1

**[deleted]** • 4y ago**swagwater67** • 4y ago

Atheist

Additionally, has there been any historical evidence of a genocide of children under the age of two during that time?



11

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

No.

**pb1940** • 4y ago

Josephus, the author of The Antiquities of the Jews, absolutely hated King Herod, and any kind of child genocide or "Slaughter of the Innocents" ordered by Herod would most certainly have been mentioned in his 40-volume history - and yet, there's not a single explicit or implicit reference at all.



6

**HiddenAgnosticYt** OP • 4y ago

Agnostic

You would think that would be very relevant.

**[deleted]** • 4y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[+](#) Create

14

**rumoursofwar** • 4y ago

A religion survives as long as Christianity because it contains enough ambiguity to make apologetics for pretty much everything, no amount of inaccuracy or contradiction is going to work.

As opposed to which unambiguous or less ambiguous world view or system of beliefs?

0

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

Irrelevant.

1

**rumoursofwar** • 4y ago

Why? Ambiguity is relative. If there is nothing less ambiguous, then there is nothing more clear.

1

**Nekronn99** • 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

You are missing the point. Whether an unambiguous or less ambiguous world view or system of beliefs existed doesn't matter. It was a criticism of Christianity's ambiguity and lack of justification that was being made, not a promotion of something else more superior.

1

**rumoursofwar** • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

You are missing the point. Whether an unambiguous or less ambiguous world view or system of beliefs existed doesn't matter. It was a criticism of Christianity's ambiguity and lack of justification that was being made, not a promotion of something else more superior.

Nah. I'm not missing the point. It's just not a fallacy of relevance the way you suggest.

One can't really judge the ambiguity of one thing without comparing it to something else.

As an analogy: Person A states "light is slow," person B counters, "light is the quickest thing known. If not, show me a thing faster."

[Skip to main content](#)[+ Create](#)

concluded to be unambiguous by comparing it to other things. Or one could simply postulate the truth.

Certainly, if the request was "show me one thing quicker than the snail," then a person could easily meet that request with, "a rabbit is (or any of the myriad of other things that are) faster than a snail."

But, since so far my request for an example of a less ambiguous thing than the Bible has met no satisfactory response, the logical conclusion would be that either all things known are equally ambiguous, or that the Bible is the least ambiguous of all things known.

⊖ ↑ 1 ↓ ...



Nekronn99 • 4y ago • Edited 4y ago

anti-theist / humanist

But, since so far my request for an example of a less ambiguous thing than the Bible has met no satisfactory response, the logical conclusion would be that either all things known are equally ambiguous, or that the Bible is the least ambiguous of all things known.

That is a truly erroneous conclusion to make.

The logical conclusion is that the "bible" is ambiguous to no less or more degree than any other book of mythological legends, the only things that it could be compared to.

Comparing it to "all things known" is yet another fallacious argument, that of false equivalence. It is fallacious to equate the "bible" with "all things known". Its also false to say that "all things known" are equally ambiguous.

There's really no way to prove the quickness of the speed of light. Because "quick" isn't a valid measurement of anything, though the speed of light has been measured and quantified into units of speed measurement.

One could compare it to something moving at a different speed

No, one could compare the actual measurements of the speeds of different objects and determine which moved faster.

Similarly, there's really no way to prove the unambiguity of the Bible.

Except that its ambiguity (defined as *the quality of being open to more than one interpretation; inexactness*) has been demonstrated countless times by both its proponents AND its critics. It is proven to be ambiguous simply by the multitude of disparate disagreeing denominations and the various conflicting interpretations of its content.



Create



But it can be considered to be unambiguous by comparing it to other things.
Or one could simply postulate the truth.

No, it can't be concluded any such thing. The "bible" absolutely *is* completely ambiguous, can be and is interpreted in countless different ways by countless believers and denominations, and could never be described with the term "unambiguous" as long as those who believe it totally disagree on what it means.

This is why your specious request for something "less ambiguous" is a specious request and deserves no real response.

Can you propose a metric for *ambiguity*? How, exactly would you measure ambiguity in order to compare them? Until you can demonstrate an accurate measurement for "ambiguity", your request for something "less ambiguous" is utterly meaningless.

Edit: finishing my thought after some research.

↑ 1 ↓ ...

⊕ 1 more reply

⊕ 22 more replies